

RESEARCH DESIGN

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Designing Social Research

Develop Question(s)
Select Purpose for Investigation
Select Method for Answering
Question
Decide Unit of Analysis
Data Collection & Analysis

X IS RELATED TO Y

1A) DEVELOP RESEARCH QUESTION ABOUT SOCIAL WORLD

1B) SELECT PURPOSE FOR INVESTIGATING SOCIAL WORLD

- Exploration
- Description
- **Explanation**

THREE PURPOSES OF RESEARCH

EXPLORATION

- Satisfy researcher's curiosity
- Test feasibility of doing extensive study
- Develop methods for subsequent study

DESCRIPTION

- Describe situations and events through scientific observation

EXPLANATION

- Answers questions of why variables (X and Y) are related, and why patterns exist

TYPES OF EXPLANATORY RESEARCH

Idiographic

EXPLANATION THAT EXHAUSTS
THE MANY IDIOSYNCRATIC
CAUSES FOR A PARTICULAR
EVENT

Nomothetic

EXPLANATION THAT IDENTIFIES ONE OR
A FEW CAUSAL FACTORS THAT
GENERALLY IMPACT A CLASS OF EVENTS

EXAMPLE: MARIJUANA OPINIONS

Idiographic

ASKING ONE PERSON WHAT INFLUENCED
HER VIEWS:

- PARENTS, TEACHERS, CLERGY, PREVIOUS
EXPERIENCES

Nomothetic

FINDING OUT ABOUT THE NUMEROUS
(CROSS-CUTTING) FACTORS THAT
INFLUENCE GENERAL OPINION

- POLITICAL ORIENTATION, GENDER, OCCUPATION,
EDUCATION

Criteria for Causality

CORRELATION

X and Y are correlated

X PRECEDES Y

The presumed cause (X variable) takes place before the effect (Y variable)

NON-SPURIOUS

The relationship b/w X and Y are non-spurious (cannot be the result of some other unmeasured variable)

2) SELECT METHOD OF INVESTIGATION

- INTERVIEWS
- SURVEYS
- FOCUS GROUPS
- CASE STUDIES
- ETHNOGRAPHY
- EXPERIMENT
- PARTICIPANT-OBSERVATION
- CONTENT/TEXT ANALYSIS
- ANALYSIS OF PREVIOUSLY ADMINISTERED SURVEYS
- CENSUS
- PUBLICLY-AVAILABLE DATA (WHERE PARTICIPANTS REMAIN ANONYMOUS)

3) UNIT OF ANALYSIS

- **INDIVIDUALS**
 - STUDENTS, VOTERS, PARENTS, CHILDREN
- **GROUPS**
 - GANG MEMBERS, FAMILIES, MARRIED COUPLES, FRIENDSHIP GROUPS
- **ORGANIZATIONS**
 - CORPORATIONS, SOCIAL ORGANIZATIONS, COLLEGES
- **SOCIAL INTERACTIONS**
 - TELEPHONE CALLS, DANCES, ONLINE CHAT ROOMS, FIGHTS
- **SOCIAL ARTIFACTS**
 - SOCIAL ARTIFACT – ANY PRODUCT OF SOCIAL BEINGS OR THEIR BEHAVIOR.

4) DATA COLLECTION

CROSS-SECTIONAL STUDY

- A STUDY BASED ON OBSERVATIONS REPRESENTING A SINGLE POINT IN TIME, A CROSS SECTION OF A POPULATION.

LONGITUDINAL STUDY

- A STUDY DESIGN INVOLVING THE COLLECTION OF DATA AT DIFFERENT POINTS IN TIME.

Types of Longitudinal Designs

	Cross-Sectional	Longitudinal		
		Trend	Cohort	Panel
Snapshot in time	X			
Measurements across time		X	X	X
Follow age group across time			X	
Study same people over time				X

TREND STUDY

A study in which a given characteristic of some population is monitored over time.

- Example: Looks at general shifts in religious affiliation over time.

COHORT STUDY

A study in which some specific subpopulation, or cohort, is studied over time.

- Example: Follows shifts in religious affiliation among those born during the Depression.

PANEL STUDY

A study in which data are collected from the same set of people at several points in time

- Example: Follows the shifts in religious affiliation among a specific group of people over time.